# The Student Engagement Instrument

## Description and purpose

The *Student Engagement Instrument* (*SEI*) provides a measure of the extent to which pupils are engaged with their school. It offers a means to identify those pupils who may be at risk of disaffection and it can help schools and researchers answer questions such as:

- How involved is this class/year group with their learning?
- Which pupils are most at risk of dropping out?
- How successful are efforts to promote school engagement?

Developed in the USA by Appleton et al. (2006), the *SEI* is targeted at secondary-school students and can be used from 12 to 18 years. The measures assess two forms of student engagement, cognitive engagement and psychological engagement. In contrast with observable aspects of engagement – behaviours such as attendance and time on task – these components involve internal states, such as self-regulation, values, personal goals (cognitive), and feelings of belonging and relationships (psychological). Through assessment of the individual's level and pattern of engagement, interventions can be tailored to identify need across five domains:

- Teacher–student relationships.
- Control and relevance of schoolwork.
- Peer support for learning.
- Future aspirations and goals.
- Family support for learning.

School engagement is a multi-dimensional construct which involves positive student behaviours such as attendance, paying attention and participation at school as well as the psychological experience of identification with the school and the sense that one is cared for, respected and belongs to the school. Behavioural components of engagement are obvious and easily measured, but may appear at a later stage in the disengagement process, when it is more difficult to intervene effectively. Disengagement is not a sudden event, but rather a process that develops over time. The ability to measure levels of cognitive and psychological engagement means that interventions can be provided earlier and preventatively, before behavioural consequences are evident, in order to avoid significant disengagement and drop out.

Engaged students perceive more support from teachers and peers and a virtuous circle of increased levels of engagement which in turn generate positive interactions with others (Osterman 2000). All schools will have some students who are relatively uninvolved, apathetic or discouraged learners. Some stages are riskier than others. Transitions such as phase transfer have been shown to increase students' vulnerability to experiences of not belonging (Goodenow 1991). Some students are particularly at risk of disaffection and of dropping out of school. Boys, pupils with special educational needs (learning difficulties and disabilities), young people who are in care and those experiencing socio-economic disadvantage tend to be more vulnerable to disengagement.

Young people who drop out of school are more at risk of not being in education, employment or training (NEET). This is itself a risk factor for other poor outcomes, including youth offending. Reducing the numbers of young people who are not engaged with their learning is a priority for national government (DCSF 2007). A reduction in numbers of 16–18-year-olds NEET is the most commonly selected indicator of progress in agreements between local authorities and central government: 115 out of 150 Local Area Agreements include this indicator (NAO 2008).

The 2007 estimate of the proportion of sixteen- to eighteen-year-olds NEET in England was around 9.4 per cent. A report by the National Audit Office found that young people NEET have much lower levels of educational attainment and tend to have poorer experiences of schooling. They were also found to have been less engaged with most aspects of their school experience at age 13/14, with many reporting that lessons were a waste of time or boring. Young people NEET were also found to have been more likely to truant or to have been excluded.

The *School Engagement Instrument* is designed to measure cognitive and psychological engagement from the student perspective. The main driver to its development came from evidence that school engagement can be significantly enhanced through appropriate intervention. In particular, experience of the successful 'Check and Connect' programme (Appleton et al. 2008) has influenced this work. Based on a wide-ranging review of relevant literature, the *SEI* is also informed in particular by self-determination theory (Ryan and Deci 2000) and the theoretical work of Baumeister and Leary (1995) and Osterman (2000) on belonging.

## Administration

The *SEI* is a self-report questionnaire which includes 33 statements that students are asked to rate on a four-point ordinal scale, ranging from 'Strongly agree' to 'Strongly disagree'. An anglicised version is provided which includes some changes to vocabulary to fit the UK context.

The *SEI* can be administered to whole-class groups, to small groups and to individuals. In order to gain maximum co-operation, it is important to explain the purpose of the questionnaire and to give appropriate assurances about confidentiality. It is advisable for an adult to circulate whilst pupils complete the questionnaire to answer any queries and to provide support to pupils whose literacy or language needs might present a barrier to accurate completion of the instrument. Approximately 40 minutes should be allowed for completion.

## Scoring

Items are scored 1, 2, 3 or 4, with 4 for 'Strongly agree' responses and 1 for 'Strongly disagree'. Items should be summed to produce a total score. High scores on individual items and for summed items are associated positively with good engagement and low scores indicate weaker engagement.

## Interpretation

Scores may be interpreted to identify how well the school is performing in relation to engagement and to identify levels of engagement among year groups, classes or other groups.

**Table 1.3 Domains of disengagement**

Student details:

| Total score | Quartile | Risk (H,M,L) | Domain of concern | Items | Score on domain | Interventions |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Teacher–student relationships | 1–9 | | 'Check and Connect' |
| | | | Control and relevance of schoolwork | 10–18 | | Curriculum review |
| | | | Peer support for learning | 19–24 | | Peer mentoring programme |
| | | | Future aspirations and goals | 25–29 | | Careers advice |
| | | | Family support for learning | 30–33 | | Family meetings |

For individual pupils, scores may be analysed in three ways: in relation to *full engagement, comparatively among students and diagnostically.*

- A total score of 132 (average of 4 on each scale) represents 'the ideal' maximum score possible on the measure or '*full engagement*'. The lower the total score, the less the student is engaged cognitively and psychologically with school and so the greater the risk of disengagement. Reschley et al. (2008) report that average scale scores are typically high – approaching or surpassing '3' on the four-point scale. Atypically low scores, around or below 2, would appear to warrant further consideration.
- *Comparisons* between individuals and groups will be useful. Differences in overall engagement will be evident between areas, schools and year groups. Currently, there are no UK norms for this instrument. It may be helpful, therefore, to organise the scores of coherent groups – such as classes – into quartiles, thereby identifying individuals at different levels of relative risk. Interventions to improve engagement may be targeted at any students whose scores are out of line with the majority of their classmates or at all students appearing in lower quartiles, depending on thresholds and the purpose of the assessment.
- *Diagnostically*, scores may be analysed to identify domains of disengagement, for individuals, groups and classes. For example, see Table 1.3.

## Technical details

Appleton et al. (2006) report evidence from factor analyses which supports both the convergent and discriminant validity of the factor structure underpinning the instrument. Internal consistency is adequate, with coefficient alpha values ranging from .88 (teacher–student relationships) to .72 (extrinsic motivation). The factors of student–teacher relationships, peer support for learning, future aspirations and goals, family support for learning and extrinsic motivation each correlated with some academic and behavioural variables in

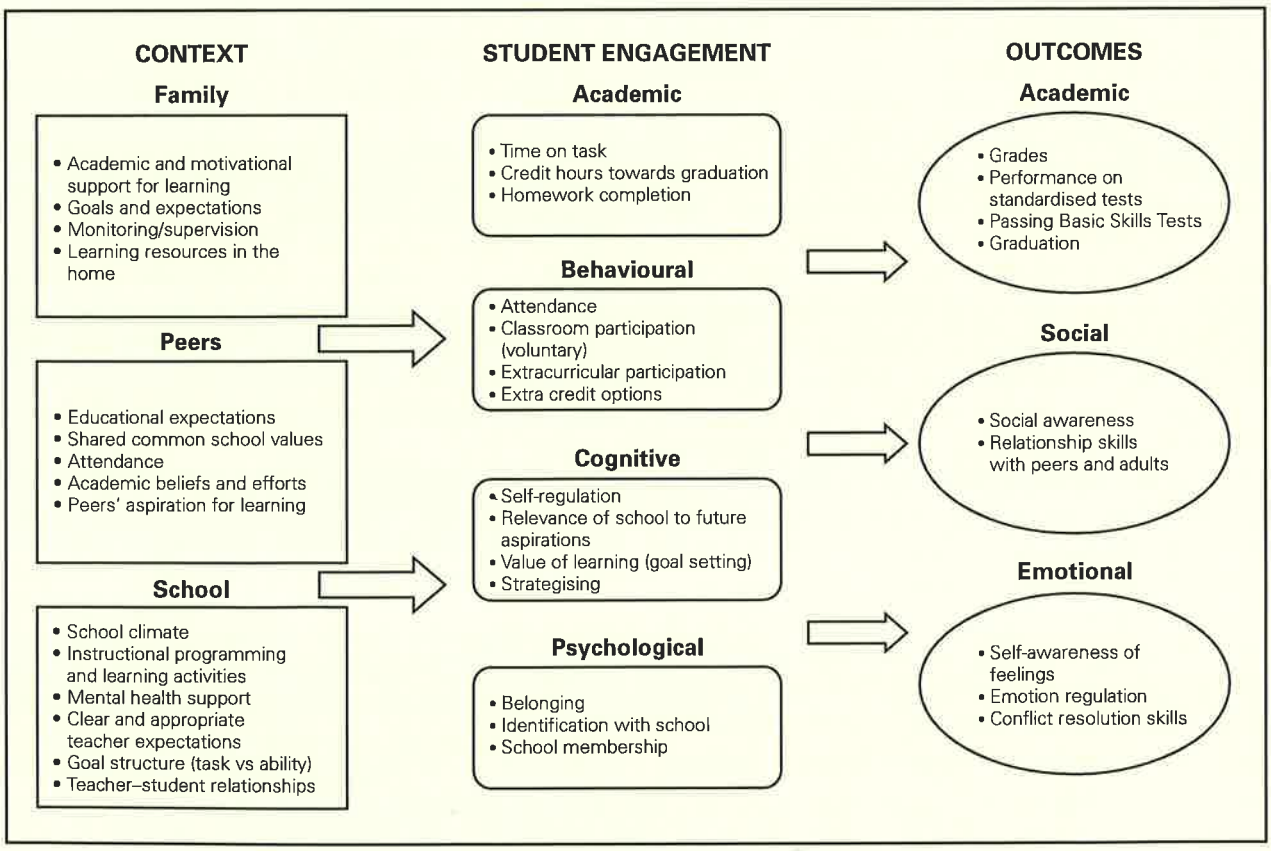


Figure 1.2 Engagement subtypes, indicators and outcomes (from Appleton et al. 2006)

# THE STUDENT ENGAGEMENT INSTRUMENT

GL assessment
the measure of potential

Name ..... Date .....

Age ..... Class ..... Please circle: Male / Female

| | | Strongly disagree ← | | → | Strongly agree |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 1. | Overall, adults at my school treat students fairly. | | | | |
| 2. | Adults at my school listen to the students. | | | | |
| 3. | At my school, teachers care about students. | | | | |
| 4. | My teachers are there for me when I need them. | | | | |
| 5. | The school rules are fair. | | | | |
| 6. | Overall, my teachers are open and honest with me. | | | | |
| 7. | I enjoy talking to the teachers here. | | | | |
| 8. | I feel safe at school. | | | | |
| 9. | Most teachers in my school are interested in me as a person, not just as a student. | | | | |
| 10. | The tests in my classes do a good job of measuring what I'm able to do. | | | | |
| 11. | Most of what is important to know you learn in school. | | | | |
| 12. | The teachers in my classes do a good job of measuring what I'm able to do. | | | | |
| 13. | What I'm learning in my classes will be important in my future. | | | | |
| 14. | After finishing my schoolwork, I check it over to see if it's correct. | | | | |
| 15. | When I do schoolwork, I check to see whether I understand what I'm doing. | | | | |
| 16. | Learning is fun because I get better at something. | | | | |
| 17. | When I do well in school, it's because I work hard. | | | | |

# THE STUDENT ENGAGEMENT INSTRUMENT

GL assessment
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| | | Strongly disagree ← | | → | Strongly agree |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| 18. | I feel like I have a say about what happens to me at school. | | | | |
| 19. | Other students at school care about me. | | | | |
| 20. | Students at my school are there for me when I need them. | | | | |
| 21. | Other students here like me the way I am. | | | | |
| 22. | I enjoy talking to the students here. | | | | |
| 23. | Students here respect what I have to say. | | | | |
| 24. | I have some friends at school. | | | | |
| 25. | I plan to continue my education following school. | | | | |
| 26. | Going to university or college after school is important. | | | | |
| 27. | School is important for achieving my future goals. | | | | |
| 28. | My education will create many future opportunities for me. | | | | |
| 29. | I am hopeful about my future. | | | | |
| 30. | My family/carer(s) are there for me when I need them. | | | | |
| 31. | When I have problems at school, my family/carer(s) are willing to help me. | | | | |
| 32. | When something good happens at school, my family/carer(s) want to know about it. | | | | |
| 33. | My family/carer(s) want me to keep trying when things are tough at school. | | | | |

**Total Score** =

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This measure is part of *Measures of Children's Mental Health and Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education and Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment Ltd, The Chiswick Centre, 414 Chiswick High Road, London W4 5TF, UK.